OXFORD, UNITED KINGDOM

Ashmolean Museum: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings and drawings that reveal where an artist concentrated attention.



A face may be carefully resolved while the shoulders remain scarcely indicated. A canal can acquire depth from a few ink lines. An isolated arm can show more about the construction of a body than a crowded narrative does. This selection uses the Ashmolean's paintings and drawings together, so that differing degrees of finish become something to read rather than a simple distinction between complete and incomplete work.

Uccello's tightly organised hunt provides one starting point; Manet's broadly handled portrait offers another. Between them are landscapes, literary scenes and likenesses in which the distribution of detail determines what can be known and what remains open.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/ashmolean-museum

The selection · 20

1. The Hunt in the Forest
   Paolo Uccello · c. 1465–1470
2. Portrait of a Youth, Possibly a Self-Portrait
   Raphael · c. 1498–1499
3. Andrea Quaratesi
   Michelangelo · 1532
4. The Exposure of Moses
   Nicolas Poussin · c. 1650
5. Ophelia
   Arthur Hughes · c. 1863
6. The Daydream
   Dante Gabriel Rossetti · 1872 - 1878
7. Girl in a Bonnet with Her Head on a Blue Pillow
   Anna Alma-Tadema · 1902
8. Asolo
   Edith Corbet · 1899
9. Dolo on the Brenta
   Canaletto · 1728
10. The Grand Canal near the Rialto Bridge
    Canaletto · 1725
11. Hester Tradescant and Her Stepson, John
    Thomas de Critz · 1645
12. Over the Hills of Kurdistan: Flying above Kirkuk
    Sydney Carline · 1919
13. The Poor Actress's Christmas Dinner
    Robert Braithwaite Martineau · c. 1860
14. Katherine and Petruchio
    Robert Braithwaite Martineau · 1855
15. Thomas Balston
    Mark Gertler · 1921
16. Copse by a Lake in Autumn
    Isaac Levitan · 1898
17. View on the Nile
    Thomas Seddon · 1855
18. Beech Trees at Sunset, Kensington Gardens
    Paul Maitland · 1905
19. Portrait of Mademoiselle Claus
    Édouard Manet · 1868
20. Study of an Upper Arm
    Matthias Grünewald · 1512 - 1514

01 / 20

The Hunt in the Forest

Paolo Uccello

c. 1465–1470 · Tempera and oil on panel, with traces of gold · Ashmolean Museum



Paolo Uccello. The Hunt in the Forest. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The riders and hounds recede among repeated tree trunks toward the forest’s centre. Uccello planned this space with a perspective grid, but the night setting withholds the clear view that such organisation might seem to promise. The museum describes the nocturnal hunt as playful or symbolic rather than a realistic report: precision and invention work together.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Portrait of a Youth, Possibly a Self-Portrait

Raphael

c. 1498–1499 · Black chalk with white heightening · Ashmolean Museum



Raphael. Self Portrait. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The youth’s eyes and cheek receive concentrated shadow while hair and cap can be established with fewer marks. The possible self-portrait identification remains a possibility, not a conclusion supplied by the face’s directness. The drawing is specific as a likeness even while the sitter’s name remains unsettled.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Andrea Quaratesi

Michelangelo

1532 · Chalk on paper · Ashmolean Museum



Portrait of Andrea Quaratesi. WikiArt; Michelangelo. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The carefully modelled head and more lightly indicated shoulders invite different kinds of attention. Shading gives the face continuity, while the clothing makes fewer claims to a finished surface. Michelangelo lets the drawing develop around its principal encounter; the less resolved areas help disclose where that concentration lies.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

The Exposure of Moses

Nicolas Poussin

c. 1650 · Oil on canvas · Ashmolean Museum



Nicolas Poussin. The Exposure of Moses. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/nicolas-poussin/the-exposition-of-moses · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The child’s position beside the water gives several figures something to respond to, but their gestures do not collapse into one action. Trees and distant buildings extend the setting beyond the group. Poussin uses that room to distinguish responses, making the biblical episode readable through relations among people and places.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Ophelia

Arthur Hughes

c. 1863 · Ashmolean Museum



Arthur Hughes. Ophelia. Image credit: Arthur Hughes; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Hughes keeps Ophelia upright beside a tree, surrounded by vegetation and holding flowers. The picture should not be confused with the floating figure in Millais's treatment or Hughes's earlier seated version. Here the pale standing body is enclosed by growth; the subject's association with water remains a threat around her rather than a completed event.

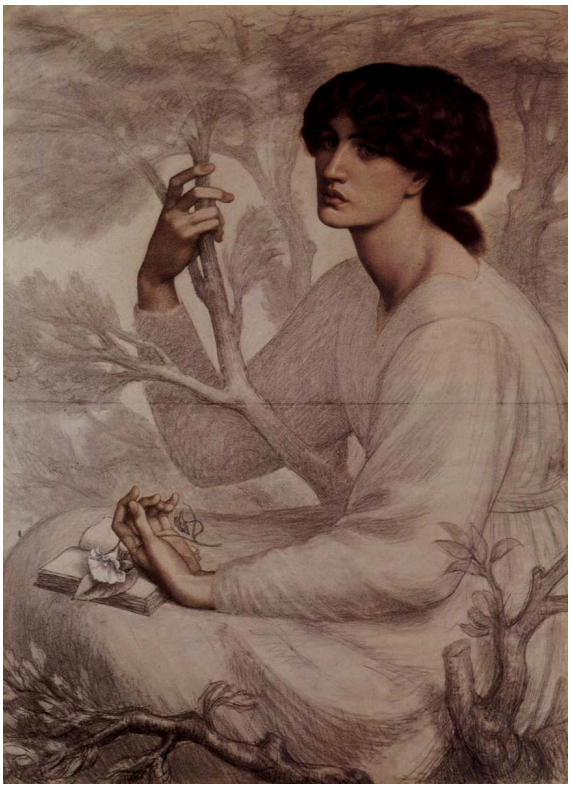
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1977.23

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The Daydream

Dante Gabriel Rossetti

1872 - 1878 · Ashmolean Museum



Dante Gabriel Rossetti. The Daydream. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/dante-gabriel-rossetti/the-daydream-1878 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The book lies open, but the woman’s attention no longer follows its page. A small branch raised near the hands offers another point of focus. The lightly described setting gives the pause room without explaining it. Interrupted reading is visible; the content of the daydream is not.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Girl in a Bonnet with Her Head on a Blue Pillow

Anna Alma-Tadema

1902 · Ashmolean Museum



Anna Alma-Tadema. Girl in a Bonnet with her Head on a Blue Pillow. Image credit: Anna Alma-Tadema; Source credit: https://wsimag.com/art/12787-great-british-drawings. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The cheek rests against the blue pillow, making contact between face and fabric the centre of the image. The bonnet's ruffles and other pale materials surround that pressure of one soft surface against another. Blue remains emphatic enough for the support to share attention with the person it carries.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1964.81

08 / 20

Asolo

Edith Corbet

1899 · Ashmolean Museum



Edith Corbet. Asolo. Image credit: Edith Corbet; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The buildings do not occupy the view as isolated attractions. Fields and long stretches of ground connect them to a larger inhabited terrain. Corbet's broad sky permits those intervals to remain important. The town is approached through the land around it, rather than presented as a complete object ready to be inspected.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1969.20

09 / 20

Dolo on the Brenta

Canaletto

1728 · Oil on canvas · Ashmolean Museum



Canaletto. Dolo on the Brenta. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/canaletto/dolo-on-the-brenta · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The waterway connects architecture to use: buildings line it, and modest figures and working structures belong along its edge. The bell tower supplies a clear vertical among the low roofs. Canaletto separates distances sufficiently for small actions to register without making them compete with the whole town.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

The Grand Canal near the Rialto Bridge

Canaletto

1725 · Ink on paper · Ashmolean Museum



The Grand Canal near the Ponte del Rialto. WikiArt; Canaletto. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Some edges are reinforced by repeated ink strokes while others are left open. Boats, façades and the canal's direction can be recognised without the continuous surfaces of a finished painting. The drawing makes selection conspicuous: a few decisive lines establish space, and detail accumulates where it is most useful.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Hester Tradescant and Her Stepson, John

Thomas de Critz

1645 · Ashmolean Museum



Thomas de Critz. Hester Tradescant and her Stepson, John. Image credit: Thomas de Critz; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The meeting of the hands gives the woman and boy a shared point within the foreground. Their different heights and clothing remain distinct around it. The double portrait therefore has more structure than two likenesses placed side by side: a small connection helps hold the family relationship in view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1898.14

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Over the Hills of Kurdistan: Flying above Kirkuk

Sydney Carline

1919 · Ashmolean Museum



Sydney Carline. Over the Hills of Kurdistan: Flying above Kirkuk. Image credit: Sydney Carline; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The aircraft wing interrupts the land below, insisting that this elevated view comes from a particular machine. Other aeroplanes share the space above hills and fields. Carline does not offer an unobstructed panorama. Flight changes what can be seen, and the means of seeing it remain within the picture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1929.30

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The Poor Actress’s Christmas Dinner

Robert Braithwaite Martineau

c. 1860 · Ashmolean Museum



Robert Braithwaite Martineau. The poor Actress's Christmas Dinner. Image credit: Robert Braithwaite Martineau; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The small dish claims attention disproportionate to its size because so little else is fully stated. Much of the woman’s body remains lightly indicated around the act of eating. The title proposes poverty as the scene’s condition; the drawing brings that condition close through the scale of the meal rather than a catalogue of missing possessions.

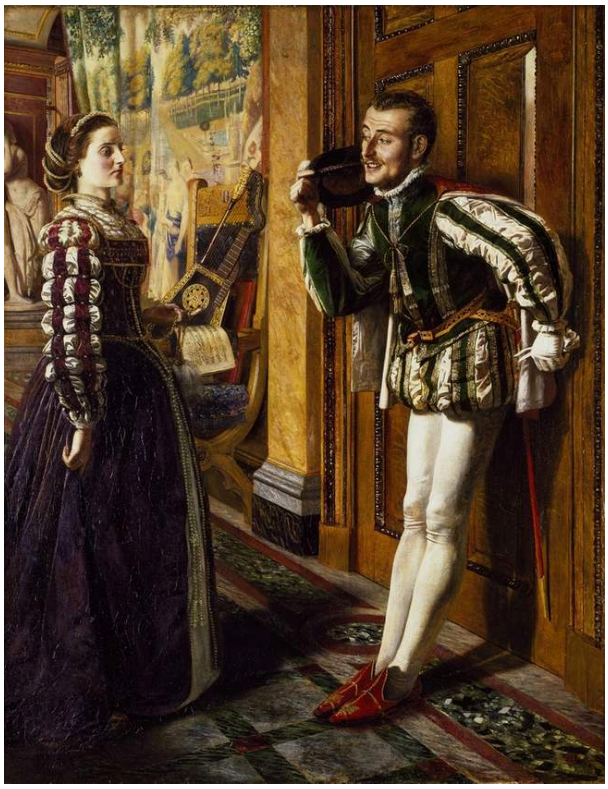
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1941.61

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Katherine and Petruchio

Robert Braithwaite Martineau

1855 · Ashmolean Museum



Robert Braithwaite Martineau. Katherine and Petruchio. Image credit: Robert Braithwaite Martineau; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The raised vessel and opposing postures turn the furnished room into a place of confrontation. Costume and setting locate the exchange within performed social roles, but gestures make it legible before every literary reference is identified. The scene asks for attention to the physical terms of an argument, not merely the names in its title.

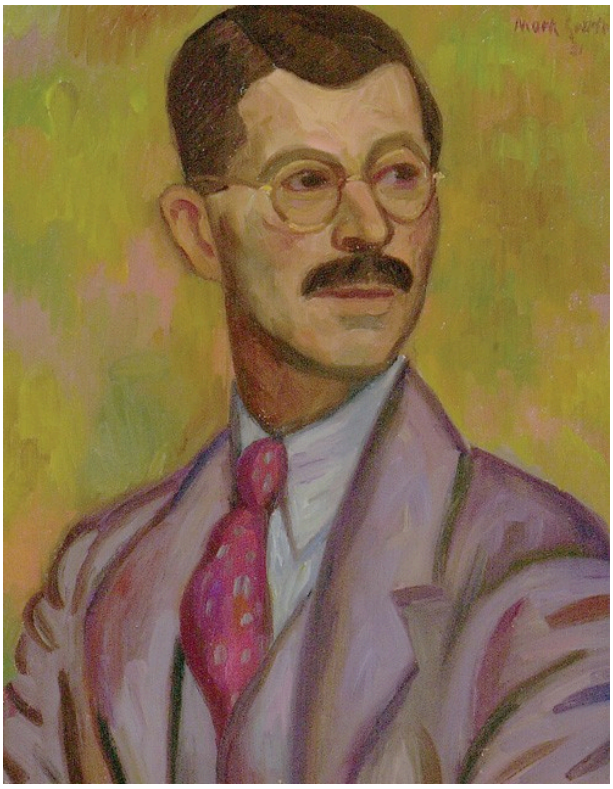
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1950.197

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Thomas Balston

Mark Gertler

1921 · Ashmolean Museum



Mark Gertler. Thomas Balston. Image credit: Mark Gertler; Source credit: Ashmolean Museum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The lilac jacket and greenish ground separate sitter from surroundings through colour. Against those broad areas, the head is more precisely described, with the bright tie providing a smaller accent below. The difference in handling gives the face priority without requiring a spotlight or an elaborate account of the sitter’s profession.

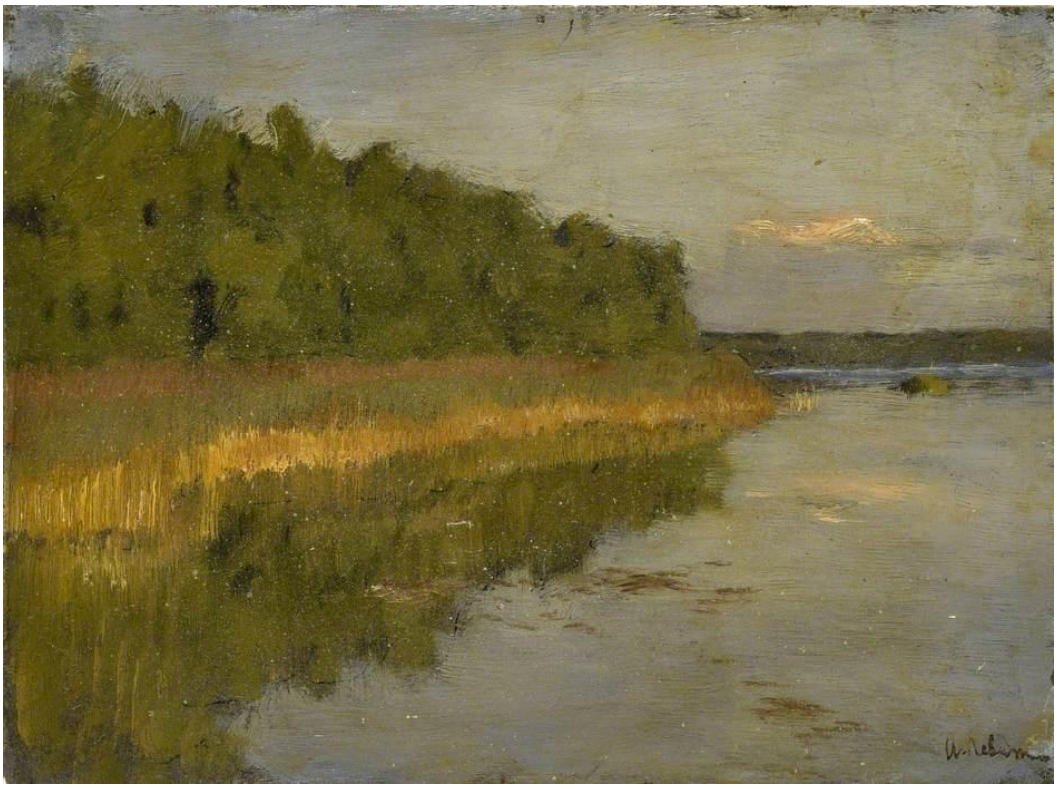
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1968.21

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Copse by a Lake in Autumn

Isaac Levitan

1898 · Ashmolean Museum



Isaac Levitan. Copse by a Lake (Autumn). Image credit: Isaac Levitan; Source credit: Art UK. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The low bank continues through trees, reeds and their darker reflections. Autumn appears in adjustments of colour rather than a dramatic incident or an exceptional landmark. That continuous edge allows small changes to accumulate. The painting offers a season as a condition spread across an ordinary place.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1949.313

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View on the Nile

Thomas Seddon

1855 · Ashmolean Museum



Thomas Seddon. View on the Nile. Image credit: Thomas Seddon; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The pale sail introduces a diagonal into a view otherwise dominated by the long meeting of bank, water and evening sky. Reflections keep the river connected to distant light. The boats remain particular objects, but they do not close the composition around themselves; the horizontal extent continues beyond them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1944.31

18 / 20

Beech Trees at Sunset, Kensington Gardens

Paul Maitland

1905 · Ashmolean Museum



Paul Maitland. Beech Trees at Sunset, Kensington Gardens. Image credit: Paul Maitland; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Tree trunks repeat closely enough to limit the distant view. Depth has to be found in the small lit gaps between them rather than through a broad opening. Maitland gives the garden a contained space, built from repetition and filtered light instead of a single prominent tree or sweeping prospect.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: WA1961.31

19 / 20

Portrait of Mademoiselle Claus

Édouard Manet

1868 · Ashmolean Museum



Édouard Manet. Portrait of Mademoiselle Claus. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/edouard-manet/portrait-of-mademoiselle-claus-1868 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The face is more resolved than the dress and the partly developed figure beside it. A green railing helps hold this unevenly finished arrangement together. Manet's portrait can therefore be read at two levels: as a likeness and as evidence of decisions still differently visible across the same painted surface.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Study of an Upper Arm

Matthias Grünewald

1512 - 1514 · Chalk · Ashmolean Museum



Matthias Grünewald. Upper arm Study. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/matthias-grunewald/forearm-study-1514 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The arm is detached from the larger action it might eventually perform. Chalk and lighter passages are enough to model its curve, making an anatomical fragment available for close study. Isolation changes the task: instead of following a story, attention can remain on how contour and shading give one part of a body force.

Object source · Open artwork

Look where the finish changes

Compare the three early figure drawings with Manet’s portrait and Canaletto’s ink view. Ask what is established first, and what can remain abbreviated without being lost. Works on paper and paintings may have different display arrangements; use the museum’s current records to check availability rather than treating this selection as a fixed itinerary.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed’s discussions of line and tone provide practical language for the Raphael, Michelangelo, Canaletto and Grünewald drawings. They are most useful when read beside the actual differences in mark and degree of finish.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12